

Microsoft Releases Source Code of .NET for Linux and Mac OS!

Microsoft is accumulating all the next-gen .NET components under a single umbrella, named .NET 2015.

It seems like the sky is the limit for Microsoft, as Satya Nadella leads it on a journey of rapid reinvention. It's a historical moment for Microsoft as its very own .NET framework has been open sourced completely, and that too to function across platforms like Linux and Apple Mac OS, the arch rivals of the Redmond tech giant's Windows OS. The crucial move towards broadening Microsoft's footprint in the world of open source computing was announced at Connect(), the virtual developers' event in New York City.

.NET as open source, though not for the first time

It's not the first time that .NET has been open-sourced, though. In April this year, at the Build conference, the first step was taken to open source the platform, and multiple .NET components were released as open source projects, under the .NET Foundation. But now the process has been taken to the next stage of development, as the entire source code has been open sourced and the versions will be made available for diverse platforms including Linux and OS X. Now, .NET will pose tough competition for Oracle's Java, which is already a cross-platform software development solution. The latest move by Microsoft will attract developers who use a variety of open source technologies and build cloud applications through multiple components. The .NET framework will no longer remain the programming model for developers who build apps only on Windows.

.NET: Not dependent on the Mono project

If we're to go by the recent development history of Microsoft, the latest announcement is not such a huge shock. According to S. Somasegar, corporate VP developer division, Microsoft Corp, the company now has an offering, which will be both relevant and attractive for developers working on any application. In this way, Microsoft is grabbing every possible opportunity to stay on top in the modem software and online services era, rather than resting on its laurels thanks to Windows reigning supreme on the desktop.

Earlier, the Mono project allowed developers to use the .NET framework on non-Windows platforms, but now that dependence is no longer necessary. The Mono project is an open source implementation of the .NET stack, and it's managed by Xamarin, a vendor of cross-platform mobile development tools. A new GitHub repository has also been created, where the code of .NET will be open sourced.

Somasegar is hoping that the switch to open source will be completed in the next few months.

There are several advantages of .NET as an open source package, which go much beyond just simple community-based development. Developers will be permitted to include .NET framework components in container applications as well. .NET components will be open sourced under the Apache 2.0 licence, and this will allow developers to use the code in proprietary projects too.

The history of .NET and Microsoft's struggles in the open source market

.NET dates back to 2002 when it was released by Microsoft for developers to build applications on Windows. During its development stage, several internal complications arose within the company. Then, experimentation started with cross-platforms in the form of the Silverlight framework, which was an implementation of .NET to run on the Mac OS. But support for Silverlight didn't continue for long. Then, during 2007-08, open source technologies started emerging fast in the marketplace, as Google released the Android OS as open source software and GitHub opened its repositories for open source code. Though the world was changing fast, Microsoft was unable to keep up with the advancements.

.NET today

Ever since Satya Nadella took charge of the company as its CEO, things have changed for Microsoft. The company is now striving hard to meet developers' requirements. Microsoft is accumulating all the next-gen .NET components under a single umbrella, named .NET 2015. This also includes .NET 4.6, which is the next update to the desktop .NET framework. Somasegar believes this new development will open up a bunch of new opportunities for Microsoft's partners as well. He acknowledges that Nadella has played a crucial role in the direction Microsoft is going with regard to its openness, and commends Nadella for his foresight and continuous drive towards more and more development. Certainly, an open source .NET will make Microsoft software more appealing to developers. 

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